

For each session below, every child and parent will get to vote. For each session, you will vote for one of the starred choices. Each five week session will also include the following:

- A biography of the author
- Historical context about the time during which the book was written
- Historical context about the book's setting if it is different than the time it was written
- Discussions of character, plot, setting, and symbolism

Session I (January 4 - February 1)

- ★ **Swiss Family Robinson** by Johann Wyss (Great Illustrated Classics version)
 - **Swiss Family Robinson:** A big storm smashes a ship against the rocks, and one family is stranded on a mysterious tropical island. Father, Mother, and four sons have to figure out how to survive with only what they can rescue from the wreck. They build an amazing treehouse home high in the branches, tame wild animals, and discover fruits, crops, and even a few surprises hiding in the jungle. Every day brings a new adventure, from hunting and fishing to exploring caves and beaches. Working together, the family turns the wild island into a home. But will anyone ever find them and take them back to the world they left behind?
- ★ **Captains Courageous** by Rudyard Kipling (Great Illustrated Classics version)
 - **Captains Courageous:** Harvey Cheyne is a rich, spoiled boy who has never had to work, never been told no, and never learned what it means to be a man. Then one stormy night he tumbles off an ocean liner and is pulled from the waves by a fishing boat! The rough, kind-hearted fishermen don't care how rich his father is, and Captain Disko Troop puts him to work right away. Harvey learns to bait hooks, clean fish, and stand watch in scary storms, with tough men like Long Jack and Manuel patiently showing him how it's done. Dan, the captain's son, becomes his first real friend and teaches him the ropes. Slowly Harvey discovers that being a man means working hard, telling the truth, and being brave and kind to others. By summer's end he is strong, capable, and respected - he has become a man.

Session II (February 8 - March 8)

- ★ **David Copperfield** by Charles Dickens (Great Illustrated Classics version)
 - **David Copperfield:** David is a kind and curious boy whose life takes some very hard turns. After his father dies, his cruel stepfather sends him away from home, and he ends up working in a dirty factory far from anyone who loves him. David decides to run away and walk all the way to his Aunt Betsey's house, where he finally finds a home. Along the way he meets unforgettable characters, like the endlessly cheerful Mr. Micawber, the sneaky Uriah Heep, and his sweet friend Peggotty. David grows up, goes to school, becomes a writer, and learns who his true friends are. This is a story about never giving up, even when life is tough!
- ★ **Little House in the Big Woods** by Laura Ingalls Wilder

- **Little House in the Big Woods:** Laura lives with Ma, Pa, and her sisters in a snug log cabin deep in the big woods of Wisconsin, surrounded by trees as far as she can see. Every season brings something wonderful to do, like making maple candy in the snow, helping Pa hunt, or churning butter with Ma. In the evenings Pa plays his fiddle by the fire while the family listens to the wolves howl outside. Laura sometimes gets scared of the dark woods, but she always feels safe at home. There are bears, panthers, and even a surprise visit from a big family gathering at Grandpa's! This is a true story about growing up long ago, when families made almost everything they needed by hand.
- ★ The Wizard of Oz by L. Frank Baum (Great Illustrated Classics version)
 - **The Wonderful Wizard of Oz:** A giant cyclone swirls through Kansas and whisks Dorothy and her little dog Toto high into the sky, landing them in the magical Land of Oz. Dorothy just wants to go home, so she follows the yellow brick road to the Emerald City, where the great Wizard might be able to help. Along the way she meets a Scarecrow who wants a brain, a Tin Woodman who wants a heart, and a Cowardly Lion who wants courage. Together they face fierce Kalidahs, a field of sleepy poppies, and the Wicked Witch of the West, who sends flying monkeys after them! Dorothy and her friends discover that the Wizard is not quite what he seems. In the end, each friend learns they already had what they were looking for inside them all along. And with the help of her magical silver shoes, Dorothy finally learns there's no place like home!

Session III (March 15 - April 12)

- ★ Fairytales
- ★ Tales from Shakespeare
 - For both fairytales and tales from Shakespeare, we can choose a variety of tales once we decide which we would like to do. Shakespeare stories would likely come from a book titled Beautiful Stories From Shakespeare by E. Nesbitt.
 - I thought no matter which one we choose (fairytales or Shakespeare), the children could work on writing their own play retelling of one story and present their plays in the fifth week of the course. We would probably have 2-3 groups to create the plays.